THE_GIFT_&_THE_LEDGER
A_DRAMATIC_WORKSHOP_IN_THREE_ACTS

Muindi Fanuel Muindi + ylfa lund muindi
(w/environments modulated by Garrett Laroy Johnson & Brandon Mechtley)

PRE_SCRIPT:

The incorruptible "Ledger" is the abstract machine that haunts the (restricted) blockchain economy of our Promethean (or "tech-bro-methean") fantasies. Imagine, if you will, an absolutely verifiable and permanent record of all credits and debits, an unimpeachable account of who puts in and who takes out, a means to instantly expose con-artists, counterfeiters, and free-riders for what they are, whenever and wherever—forever putting an end to all market failures produced by the erosion of *trust*. Ay, and more, imagine that the "Ledger" exists everywhere and nowhere, as a decentralized and distributed system. What you have just imagined is the global blockchain economy of tomorrow, "Goodbye, Washington Consensus! Hello, Nakamoto Consensus!"

The genuine "Gift", by contrast, is the abstract machine that haunts the deconstructive (general) economy of our Epimethean fantasies. Regard, if you will, our sun, the star at the center of our solar system. In the words of George Bataille, "The origin and essence of our wealth are given in the radiation of the sun, which dispenses energy— wealth—without any return." Ay, and more, not only does our sun give without any return, our sun keeps no accounts: to think the perspective of our sun is to think nothing of con-artists, counterfeiters, and free-riders. There is no rhyme or reason in playing our sun for the fool: we can *trust* that our sun will give, give, and give as much as it can, never holding back and never wanting back. Indeed, as Georges Bataille understood, to regard our sun is to regard the general economy of the cosmos that is "always already" operating, that precedes, exceeds, and succeeds any and all restricted economies.

No doubt, the general economy of the genuine Gift is remarkably different from the restricted economy of the incorruptible Ledger, but how are we to conceive of this difference and remark upon it in ways that can make a difference to our communities, our institutions, and our relations with human and non-human others? Our workshop insists that, instead of pitting the Gift *against* the Ledger and remarking upon the differences *between* the two and their *opposition* to one another, we should think the Gift *with and through* the "Ledger" and remark upon a difference *beyond* the two, a difference that relates one to the other as an enabler. A work of performative theory, this workshop *affectively dramatizes* its insistence on "thinking with and through" instead of informatively describing or effectively demonstrating its insistence. Indeed, inspired by Augusto Boal's *Theatre of the Oppressed*, our workshop casts participants as "spect-actors" in a series of pocket-dramas investigating the economies of the Gift and the Ledger.

SCENARIO:

Imagine, if you will, a river flowing through a valley, a fluid continuum in motion, feeding fauna, flora, and fungi along its course.

Now, let us say that you walk up to this river and dip a vessel into it, a cup. In so doing, you have discretized and appropriated a portion of the river, that fluid continuum in motion. You now possess one cup of water, and you may give this cup away or keep it for yourself. At the same time, however, dipping the cup into the river and appropriating a discrete amount of water generated some spillage, some overflow. As you walk away from the river and up the hill, you will notice that, along the course that you take up the hill, water drips and drops from the cup, and from your hands and, insofar as you stepped into the river, from your feet, leaving behind little puddles, droplets, and rivulets that feed fauna, flora, and fungi that happen across them.

Now, let's say that you drink up the cup of water when you get to the top of a hill and then, in the midst of enjoying the stunning hilltop view, very suddenly, you suffer a heart attack and you die. Over the next few hours, days, weeks, scavengers and decomposers consume your dead body, each of them appropriating some portion of that cup of water that you appropriated from the river. Ay, and each and every scavenger and decomposer produces some spillage, some overflow as they appropriate some portion of this water, leaving a trail of drippings and droppings behind them as they abandon your carcass, and these drippings and droppings feed fauna, flora, and fungi that happen across them.

Then comes the rain. What remains of the puddles, droplets, and rivulets of water that you left behind you as you walked uphill, what remains of the drippings and droppings of the creatures who consumed and decomposed your corpse, and what remains of your last gulp of water in your decomposed carcass—all of this flows back down the hill and returns to the very river from which you drew your last cup of water, feeding fauna, flora, and fungi on the re-course, on the return journey to the river.

To draw a cup of water from a river is to draw a discrete portion of water from the water cycle, which is but one of the many different biogeochemical cycles and fields coursing upon, above and below the surface of the Earth. Other biogeochemical cycles include the cycles for solar and geothermal energy and the cycles for various chemical elements: calcium, carbon, hydrogen, mercury, nitrogen, oxygen, phosphorus, selenium, and sulfur. Each and every one of these biogeochemical cycles is, when regarded over some greater or lesser duration, a fluid continuum in motion which spills, overflows, drips and drops, and charts an increasingly tortuous (re-)course as discrete portions are drawn from them.

Ledgering insists upon acts of discrete appropriation—by dipping a cup into the river I can simultaneously do three things: (i) I can appropriate and carry away a cup of water from the river (i.e., the cup functions as a *store of value*); (ii) I can establish the cup as a *unit of account* for appropriations from the river (e.g., an appropriation from the river may measure one cup, or a ½ cup, or a ¼ cup, etc); and (iii) I can give a cup of water (or a fraction of a cup of water) away in exchange for something or for nothing (i.e., the cup functions as a *means of exchange*).

Gift giving insists upon acts of spillage, acts of overflow, acts of dripping and dropping, acts of torturing the (re-)course of a fluid continuum in motion—and these acts precede, exceed, and succeed any and every act of discrete appropriation.

ACT_I:_THE_LEDGER_&_THE_SIGNIFYING_CHAIN

Spect-actors take turns giving and taking *discrete physical tokens* from one another. Whenever one spect-actor gives/takes to/from another spect-actor, a third spect-actor *ledgers* this give/take by *physically linking* the giving/taking spect-actor to the spect-actor has been given-to/taken-from. Each spectator *must* either give or take a token from another spect-actor during their turn, they cannot "pass". At the end of every round of give/take, the spect-actor who possesses the *fewest* tokens is the spect-actor who "wins" the round, having accumulated the *least* amount of *debt*. This "winning" spect-actor decides the order in which each spect-actor takes their turn in the next round.

The workshop facilitators—playing the role of what Augusto Boal termed *jokers*, serving as emcees, exegetes, and "wild card" actors—will confront the spect-actors with different ecological, economic, and ethical dilemmas/dramas before their turns so that "winning" isn't necessarily the be-all-end-all for the spect-actors, so that some spect-actors might be motivated to accumulate more instead of less debt.

ACT_II:_THE_GIFT_&_THE_TORTUOUS_CIRCLE

Spect-actors take turns stretching, twisting, crumpling, bending, and winding a *single continuous physical medium* so as to *loop* portions of the medium around themselves. At the end of every round of looping, the spect-actor whose own loops are entangled with the loops of the greatest number of other spect-actors is the spect-actor who "wins" the round, having become the *keystone species*. This "winning" spect-actor decides the order in which each spect-actor takes their turn in the next round.

Again, the jokers will confront the spect-actors with different ecological, economic, and ethical dilemmas/dramas before their turns so that "winning" isn't necessarily the be-all-end-all for the spect-actors, so that some spect-actors might be motivated to eschew becoming the keystone species.

ACT_ III:_THE_DISTRIBUTED_NETWORK_&_THE_TORTUOUS_KNOTWORK

Spect-actors play the games from Act I and Act II simultaneously, one game running atop the other. At the end of each round, the spect-actor who wins the Tortuous Circle game determines the order in which individuals must take their turn in the Signifying Chain game and, in turn, the spect-actor who wins the Signifying Chain game determines the order in which individuals must take their turn in the Tortuous Circle game.

The jokers will confront the spect-actors with different different ecological, economic, and ethical dilemmas/dramas before they take their turns so that "winning" one or both games isn't necessarily the be-all-end-all for the spect-actors, so that some spect-actors might be motivated to "lose" both games, to accumulate more debt and eschew becoming the keystone species.